

Assembly of First Nations

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ANNUAL GENERAL ASSEMBLY
July 14-15-16, 2026, Ottawa, ON

Resolution no. 13/2026

TITLE: Support for Jaali's Call to Action and a National Review of Indigenous Patient Safety

SUBJECT: Health

MOVED BY: Chief Edwin Ananas, Beardy's and Okemasis First Nation, SK

SECONDED BY: Chief Erma Merasty, Shoal Lake First Nation, SK

DECISION Carried by consensus.

WHEREAS:

- A. The Treaties, the Constitution Act, 1982, the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples, and the Truth and Reconciliation Commission Calls to Action support equitable access to health care and the highest attainable standard of health for First Nations peoples.
- B. First Nations peoples continue to experience significant disparities in health outcomes and continue to raise concerns regarding racism, discrimination, barriers to care, delayed treatment, and accountability within health systems across Canada.
- C. Healthcare delivery, regulation, and investigation of clinical incidents fall primarily under provincial and territorial jurisdiction; however, First Nations continue to experience inequities in accessing culturally safe and equitable healthcare services, highlighting the need for collaboration among First Nations, federal, provincial, and territorial partners to improve patient experiences and outcomes.
- D. The Shirley Bighead Nihtāwiki and Ohpikihāwasowin Birthing and Childrearing Lodge, located on Sturgeon Lake First Nation in Saskatchewan, is a cornerstone of First Nations birthing and birthing rights and is a viable regional model that others can follow.
- E. Jaali Sutherland-Weenie was a young First Nations mother who tragically lost her life on April 26, 2026, after seeking medical care while in the late stages of pregnancy. Her death has prompted widespread concern among First Nations regarding patient safety, equitable access to care, accountability, and whether systemic barriers continue to contribute to adverse health outcomes experienced by First Nations patients and families.

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- F. The concerns raised by the Sutherland-Weenie family have contributed to broader national discussions regarding patterns in experiences of First Nations patients and families seeking care within Canadian health systems and the challenges many face in obtaining timely accountability, and meaningful participation in review processes.

THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED that the First Nations-in-Assembly:

1. Express support for the Sutherland-Weenie family in their pursuit of truth, healing, accountability, and meaningful systemic change arising from the circumstances surrounding the death of Jaali Sutherland-Weenie and express support in principle for the objectives of Jaali's Calls to Action as an important contribution to advancing culturally safe, equitable, and patient-centered healthcare.
2. Call upon the Assembly of First Nations (AFN) to work with First Nations partners, and federal, provincial, and territorial governments to better understand the national scope of systemic barriers, racism, discrimination, and inequitable treatment affecting First Nations women and families in healthcare systems, and to provide recommendations to First Nations-in-Assembly to advance patient safety, accountability, and culturally safe care.
3. Direct the AFN to strike a taskforce comprised of First Nations women and technical health professionals to develop a strategy to disseminate the recommendations to healthcare providers and provincial, territorial, and federal health administrators, policymakers and legislators, with accountability and enforceability mechanisms.
4. Support the advancement of patient safety and culturally safe care through collaboration with First Nations partners and existing initiatives, including the Cultural Safety and Humility Standard and its provisions relating to People-Centered Care, Truth and Reconciliation Commission's Calls to Action, and the Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls' Inquiry Calls for Justice, and fully recognize Joyce's Principle as a foundational framework for addressing First Nations racism in healthcare; strengthen its implementation and application across health and social service systems, as well as promote culturally appropriate and trauma-informed approaches that support First Nations individuals and families in navigating healthcare systems and accountability processes.
5. Support dedicated funding, infrastructure, and long-term resources to establish and deliver First Nations midwifery and, uphold First Nations health structures to enable First Nations to care for our people throughout the perinatal period and across the lifespan.

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